

Individual Training – Key Takeaways

Adult Learning Principles in Defence Training — Sessions 1–3

Originator Individual Training Review Date September 2026 Version Working draft v0.3

Commander's Question

What is the Army approach to individual training?

A working synthesis of the evidence so far, not a record of the sessions — to be tested and refined as the activity continues.

Emerging Takeaways

- 1 Individual training exists to produce operational competence and effect.** Course completion is a means, not an end; success is whether the individual can perform to standard in role and on operations. Digital literacy — systems, data and increasingly AI-enabled tools — is now part of that competence across the force, not only in specialist trades.
- 2 A common standard does not require an identical learning journey.** People arrive shaped by genetics, prior experience, education, environment, stress and neurodiversity. Multiple modes of instruction, assistive technology, reasonable adjustment and distributed learning give more flexible routes to the same standard.
- 3 Capability is built through sequenced practice.** The brain stays adaptable: practice, repetition, feedback and experience keep developing performance well beyond initial training. Sequence within working-memory limits and use spaced retrieval to drive skills toward automaticity — what frees capacity for judgement under pressure.
- 4 Stress is a training variable to be managed, not removed.** Too little challenge disengages, too much blocks learning. Increase complexity and pressure as competence grows, so the learner finishes able to perform under operational conditions.
- 5 Learner state governs how much learning is possible.** Sleep, fatigue, nutrition, emotional state, distraction and psychological safety all affect capacity to learn — as does purpose, since people commit when they can see why the training matters to their role.
- 6 Use the most appropriate method for the required outcome — not technology for technology's sake.** Digital learning complements face-to-face training but cannot replace the human interaction that builds teamwork, judgement and discipline; used well it prepares learners beforehand, reinforces afterwards and frees contact time. Simulation bridges theory and live performance: high-risk tasks practised safely and repeatedly, with room to fail, before real consequences.
- 7 The instructor is the adaptive element in the system.** Instructors read learner state, check understanding, give feedback, adjust pacing and know when specialist support is needed. Where digital delivery handles foundational knowledge, instructor effort should shift to coaching, guided practice and judgement.
- 8 Better evidence of individual performance is now within reach.** Digital platforms, simulation and electronic observation show strengths, gaps and remediation needs far more richly than course results — provided learning, simulation, assessment and allied systems share data securely. Analytics and AI improve visibility of readiness; they do not transfer the decision.
- 9 Technology and frameworks are enablers, not the approach.** Neuroplasticity, cognitive load, UDL, ADDIE, 70:20:10, learning platforms, simulation and AI inform how Army designs and delivers training; none is the approach itself. The binding constraint is governance, infrastructure, instructor capability, technical support and sustained ownership — though short-form distributed content is the fastest way to push updated lessons, SOPs and TTPs across the force.

The Emerging Model

Foundation → Guided Practice → Independent Practice → Applied / Experiential Learning → Performance Under Pressure

Instructor direction decreases across this progression while learner autonomy, complexity and pressure increase: high-risk and foundational training sits at the left, standardised and directive; experienced learners and professional development sit further right. How far and how fast an individual moves is set by:

Risk × Complexity × Learner Experience & Competence × Required Operational Outcome

Training is not confined to a course, classroom or school. The same progression runs as a continuous cycle across a career:

Prepare → Learn → Practise → Apply → Perform → Feedback → Reinforce / Adapt

Formal instruction, digital and distributed learning, simulation, coaching and workplace experience are complementary parts of one system, accessible before, during and after a course — making readiness continuous rather than course-bound.

Emerging Proposition

Army develops individuals progressively and continuously toward operational competence — combining direction, practice, experience, coaching and learner agency, enabled by technology and informed by evidence — according to risk, complexity, learner competence and the required operational outcome. The standard is common; the journey to it need not be identical.

An emerging proposition, carrying three sessions of evidence, to be tested against those still to come.